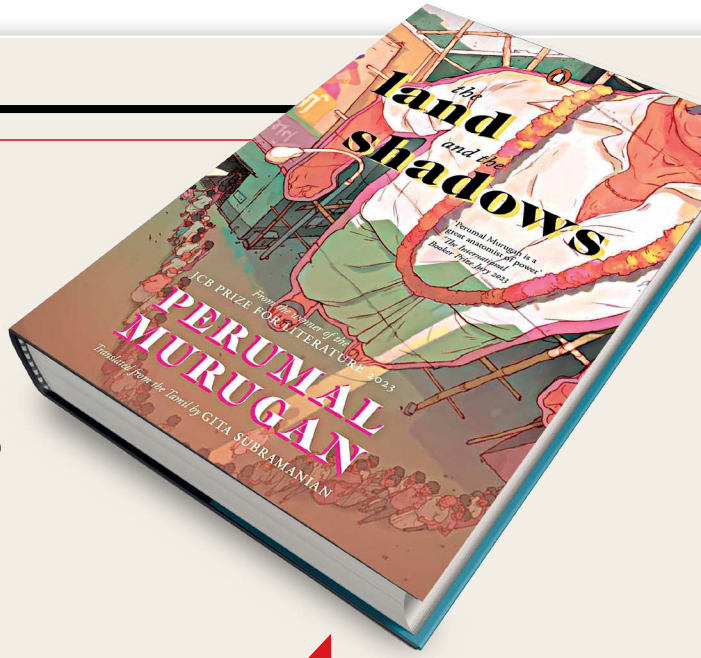
BOOKS ▼

OF SODA BOTTLES AND SILVER SCREENS

In a new collection of essays, PERUMAL MURUGAN writes about cinema and how deeply intertwined it is with Tamil society

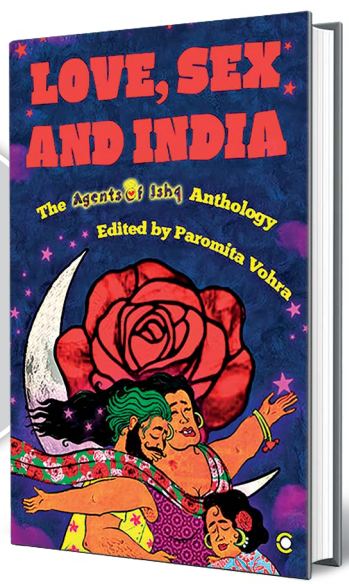


THE LAND AND THE SHADOWS
By Perumal Murugan
TRANSLATED BY GITA SUBRAMANIAN
PENGUIN/HAMISH HAMILTON
₹799; 424 pages

The sights and sounds associated with soda vendors—the mechanical grunt of the soda machine, the pop, crackle and fizz of the gleaming bottles—have been a recurring motif in Perumal Murugan's novels. A much-excerpted passage from *Pyre* talks about the physical peril associated with bottling soda. His second novel, *Nizhal Mutram* (1993; translated in 2004 by V. Geetha as *Current Show*), followed the fortunes of Sathi, a penniless soda vendor working at a cheap theatre. In Murugan's brilliant new nonfiction book *The Land and the Shadows* (translated by Gita Subramanian), a collection of 20 personal essays about cinema, we see the 'source code' for these passages. The first half a dozen essays in this book are about how, in the 1980s, Murugan's father worked as a soda vendor at a small cinema hall in Karattur, Tamil Nadu.

This batch of essays talks about the socio-economic settings in Karattur and how they shaped the behaviour and preferences of cinema-goers in the town. Remember, this is an era where physical reels were necessary for films to be projected. It's fascinating to read about how for a new M.G. Ramachandran or Sivaji Ganesan film, reels of film would be transported back and forth between different theatres on cycle-rickshaws, depending upon show timings and so on. Murugan writes about how the advent of the power loom lifted a significant number of weaver caste men from poverty, and many of these men, as they climbed the social ladder gradually, went on to start cinema halls with their newfound gains.

In the second half of the book, Murugan talks about the working-class man's relationship with his on-



LOVE, SEX AND INDIA:
The Agents of Ishq Anthology
Edited by Paromita Vohra
WESTLAND/CONTEXT
₹399; 256 pages

BOOKS ▼

UNITING ALL THE NAMES OF LOVE

The pieces in *Love, Sex and India* are less polished literary exercises and more candid articulations of intimacy

Desire, in India, has always existed in the margins—whispered, coded, or carefully contained. *Love, Sex and India*, edited by Paromita Vohra, pulls it firmly into the open, not with provocation, but with an almost disarming tenderness.

Emerging from a decade-long archive of Agents of Ishq—a digital space launched in 2015 for Indians across genders and sexualities to express their